6 LINES THE SCORECARD REWARDS, FROM SOMEONE WHO HAS FILLED IN 100+ OF THEM

What to say to ”tell me about a disagreement”

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 Start at the decision, not the person

The interviewer is listening for what was at stake, not who was wrong.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “So my manager wanted to ship without the export, and I thought that was a mistake.”
> Instead say: “The decision was whether to ship on the 14th without the export or the 21st with it.”

Name the decision in the first sentence.

2 Say what you did, in one move

The scorecard has a box for ”what did they do.” Fill it with one thing.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “I pushed back pretty hard, we went back and forth a lot.”
> Instead say: “I wrote one page with the churn number for both options and asked for ten minutes.”

One action, one sentence.

3 Say what the other person had right

Interviewers write ”listens” or ”doesn’t” in the first minute. Give them the first one.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “Honestly, they just didn’t get it.”
> Instead say: “She was right that the 14th protected the sales kickoff. I’d missed that.”

Give the other side one true point.

4 Say what shipped

The story ends when something ships, not when you win.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “...and in the end I was right.”
> Instead say: “We shipped the 14th with a smaller export and the full one on the 21st.”

End on the thing that shipped.

5 Keep it to 90 seconds

Eight minutes reads as "can't summarize." Ninety seconds reads as "has done this before."

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "(eight minutes, with the backstory)"
> Instead say: "Decision, what I did, what she had right, what shipped. Ninety seconds."

Four beats. Then stop.

6 When the disagreement was with your manager

This is the one on page 2. Two sentences, and the second one is about what you both did next.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "My manager and I didn't see eye to eye on a lot of things."
> Instead say: "My manager wanted the 14th, I wanted the 21st; I gave her the churn number for both and she picked a split. We ran the retro together and the next date decision took one meeting instead of three."

Decision, both actions, and what got better after.

Check before you send it

- [ ] Did you start at the decision?
- [ ] Is there one action in one sentence?
- [ ] Did you give the other side one true point?
- [ ] Did you end on what shipped?
- [ ] Was it under 90 seconds?